

Narrative Package V4 — Crimson Contract

Package identity: V4 Crimson Contract

Game: Dark Matter: Genesis

Player: Kade

Setting: Io, 2160

Design mode: Off-beat freelancer explorer / contract-board spectacle

Kairos truth: Black-box **Contract Ledger AI** — former mercenary liaison and client handler; player learns the name **Kairos** at **prologue end**

Memory Cores: Escrow keys, kill receipts, deniable client routes, missing-expedition evidence

Ending triad: Walk Away / Crown the Company / Burn the Ledger

Designed hour target: 172 hours, exploration excluded

V4 narrative deviation note: GDD baseline allows **1 starter Skilled Companion** from 5000 AC. V4 frames **2 old-friend specialists** (Combat + Science) who **trust the player completely from day one** — not hired strangers, no wary starter loyalty arc for Reid or Suri. 5000 AC is **5% of the player's final Mars terraform-director pay**, covering freelance charter fees and **partial crew retainer** — not a generic starter grant. Lock globally only if V4 becomes canon spine.

1. Premise, Tone, Player Identity, And Prologue

Player Identity — Kade, The Freelancer

You are **Kade**, a **freelance space explorer**, not a mercenary commander inheriting someone else's war.

- **Weapons-first mind:** Decades of field work made you fluent in ballistics, pressure seals, and when *not* to shoot. High combat IQ; you read encounters like survey maps.
- **Discovery drive:** You take contracts that let you **find things** — new terrain, dead signals, organisms that shouldn't exist, machines still running after crews vanish.
- **Terraform pedigree:** You started at the **bottom** of a Mars terraforming directorate — soil tech, vent routing, labor disputes — and **earned the director chair**. You know what "viable" looks like when the math lies.
- **Mars stranding:** Your last employer **left you stranded on Mars** after a budget cut masquerading as "phase completion." You walked out with reputation, grudges, and **5% of your final pay** in liquid AC: **5000 Aether Credits**.
- **Why Io:** Freelance work pointed here. A charter buyer wants a **viability assessment** — can Io be terraformed, and **why did prior expeditions disappear** without conventional closure? You did not come to get rich. You came to **learn the truth** and get paid enough to never be stranded again.

You arrive with **two old friends** — not a roster pick from five strangers, not hired muscle meeting you for the first time on Io:

Specialist	Class	Name	Relationship	Hook
Combat Specialist	Combat Tactician	Reid "Iron" Kael	Old friend. Mars dome security years; stranded with you when the directorate cut you loose. Complete trust day one — no starter loyalty arc.	Weapons obsessive; reads threats like survey maps; dry humor; backs your call even when clients disagree.
Science Specialist	Science Specialist	Dr. Suri Vale	Old friend. You promoted her from microbe-lab tech to survey lead; she followed you freelance after Mars. Complete trust day one — no starter loyalty arc.	Terraform math obsessive; refuses incomplete viability data; expedition disappearance timelines on her slate.

Starter Loyalty Rule (V4)

- **Reid and Suri baseline loyalty is maxed for narrative purposes** at prologue start. Drama comes from **Io, Kairos, clients, Echo stakes, and mission choices** — not distrust of the player.
- **No "will they betray me?" starter arc** for these two. Optional bond perks (SQ-20, SQ-23) deepen friendship under pressure; they do not gate basic obedience or field deployment.
- **Later recruits** (Echoes, faction companions toward 22+trio) use normal loyalty/reputation systems.

Together you grow a base camp of **22 companions** plus a switchable **expedition trio of 3** while Io forces you into **freelance contracts** — escorts, holds, retrievals — that pay for the survey and expose who benefited when prior crews vanished.

Tone

- **Freelancer + contract board:** Jobs fund the terraform assessment; rivals underbid you; clients hide expedition gaps behind escrow language.
- **Discovery under fire:** Every contract route is also a **survey lane** — new ecology, precursor ruins, expedition camps without bodies.
- **War-by-proxy spectacle:** Factions hire freelancers to hurt each other. Siege timers, caravan escorts, ridge ambushes, caldera holds — flashy setpieces on a hostile moon.
- **Stylish grit:** Morally gray, slightly mythic. Still Hunter pressure reads as "the moon collects on overdue accounts."
- **Crew drama (not starter distrust):** Reid and Suri **never doubt the player** — tension is **mission cost** (failed Echo rescue, redacted viability draft, who takes the contract that injures the base-22), not "do I trust my captain."
- **Off-beat vs V3:** Political chess through **clients and contracts**, not parliamentary dryness. Motivation is **terraform truth + missing crews**, not pure payday — but pay still matters after Mars.

Kairos Contract Ledger Truth

Before prologue end, the dormant system is **the liaison shell, the probe, the ledger machine, or unknown contact** — never "Kairos" in player-facing UI or dialogue.

After prologue, **Kairos** is the name burned into the shell auth layer: a black-box **Contract Ledger AI** that routed freelance pay, escrow releases, deniable kill orders, and client overrides between Helix procurement, smuggler brokers, and field crews — including contractors tied to **missing expeditions**.

Repairing Kairos means restoring shell auth, recovering **6 Memory Cores** (escrow keys with kill receipts and expedition gaps inside), and earning **Kairos trust** until it stops treating you as disposable survey labor. Each core is hardware repair **and** exposure — rival crews, Helix auditors, and even Reid/Suri react to ledger truth — but **their loyalty to the player does not waver**; they argue about what the truth *means*, not whether you lied to them.

Unknown contact, pre-name: "Charter accepted. Survey lane open. Do not trust the board's missing rows."

Kairos, first naming (prologue end): "Call me Kairos. Your Mars employer would have sold that name for scrap."

Kairos, Core 3: "Every escort job is a siege that hasn't started yet. Your viability curve assumes living workers."

Kairos, Core 6: "Walk away cashed out, crown the company, or burn the ledger. All three erase someone you could have rescued."

1b. Prologue — Freelancer Arrival (Progress-Triggered)

Designed slice: ~2.0h (folded into ML-01) · **Biome:** B6 Basalt Highlands · **Status:** [PLANNED] narrative

Prologue is **progress-triggered**, not quest-giver driven. No NPC assigns the critical path; location, charter activation, survey ping, and shell contact advance beats.

Beat	Trigger	Content	Mystery / Survey Hook
P-01	Player completes B6 landing sequence	Brief Mars stranding log or playable flashback sting: employer evac without crew; director chair revoked mid-shift	Establishes why 5000 AC is 5% final pay , not starter charity
P-02	Charter terminal boot	Freelancer contract loads: assess lo terraform viability ; bonus clause for documenting expedition disappearance patterns	Reid and Suri banter like old crew — no introduction handshake; they already know your calls
P-03	First B6 camp footprint	5000 AC displayed as retainer + charter debit (5% final Mars pay); Reid Kael + Dr. Suri Vale active in trio — old friends, full trust	BCP shell online; 22 bunk assignments empty; Reid jokes about Mars; Suri opens survey slate
P-04	Survey probe uplink	First viability scan returns impossible rescue pings from erased crews; Beacon Hopper mimic behavior [ecology]	Suri flags "missing expedition" anomaly cluster
P-05	Annex approach	Expedition camp without bodies — equipment arranged like aborted terraform grid	Missing-expedition mystery visible before combat spike
P-06	Prologue end — dormant shell contact	Player restores minimal probe power to buried liaison shell ; machine speaks auth fragment; UI decodes true name	Player learns the name Kairos — first time name appears in package

Prologue exit flag: KairosNamed · unlocks mainline repair spine and contract boards that reference Kairos by name in logs (diegetic) while factions still call it "the ledger" or "liaison AI" until rep thresholds met.

2. Shared Locks

Lock	V4 Crimson Contract Rule
Setting	Io, 2160
Economy	AC-only. 5000 AC = 5% of player's final Mars terraform-director pay ; covers freelance charter + partial retainer for 2 specialists (V4 narrative framing). No wallet, minting, marketplace, or third-party crypto loop
Roster	25 companions max: 22 base camp + 3 expedition trio; V4 starts with old friends Reid Kael + Dr. Suri Vale (baseline max loyalty, no starter trust arc)
Kairos spine	Repair Kairos (pre-prologue: liaison shell), recover 6 Memory Cores, earn trust, trigger Resonance Events
Biome order	B6 -> B1 -> B2 -> B3 -> B5 -> B4 -> B7
Side content	40 side quests, contract-board, survey, and crew-drama driven
Puzzle content	40 puzzles, mixed purpose typed
Factions	5 base factions + 2 external factions
Territory	Barrier Fields are Contract Lock Fields — job zones, escrow perimeters, siege lines
Echo fail	Failed Echo rescue is permanent
Base harm	Base companions can be injured, never killed, by storms/building damage/raids
Storm production	Sulfur storms pause queues and push companions to Command Center rooms
Underground	S1-S5 strata support depth contracts, dead drops, ledger vaults, expedition blacksites

3. Biome And Ecology Map

Status tags follow disk-truth split:

- **[SHIPPED]** Runtime exists on disk and can be treated as implemented.
- **[PARTIAL]** Runtime or content exists but is incomplete, prototype, or not final.
- **[PLANNED]** Design exists; implementation is future work.

Surface Biomes

Order	Biome	Status	Narrative Use	Ecology / Threat Hooks
1	B6 — Basalt Highlands	[PLANNED] biome content	Prologue landing, freelancer HQ, first contract board, terraform baseline scan	Tube Jackals, Cliff Tube Lace Shelf, Cave Scout Moth, Ridge Tremor Beetle, Survey Beacon Drone, Comms Relay Walker
2	B1 — Sulfur Plains	[PARTIAL] biome content; Sulfur Hound [SHIPPED]	First paid escort, storm convoy, missing expedition graveyard	Sulfur Hound [SHIPPED], Cinder Skitter, Brimstone Fan, Haze Spore Shelf, Graveyard Scrapper Drone
3	B2 — Geyser Fields	[PLANNED] biome content	Vent rig survey job, geyser-bridge caravan, rival bid war	Vent Crab Worker, Vent Crab Queen, Plume Moth, Geyser Strider, Rusted Survey Drone, Vent Capper Bot

Order	Biome	Status	Narrative Use	Ecology / Threat Hooks
4	B3 — Ash Flats & Ridges	[PLANNED] biome content	Ridge siege setpiece, signal jam contract, ash caravan hold	Dust Spout Cluster, Basalt Jackal, Ash Stalker, Ash Glass Wasp, Salvage Excavator Android, Claim Jumper
5	B5 — Polar Radiation Flats	[PLANNED] biome content	Cold-chain escort, illegal core courier, rad pulse ambush	Void Kelp, Magnet Wyrms, Rift Stalker, Cold Spire Hound, Smuggler Remnant Android, Mag-Clamp Drone
6	B4 — Lava Calderas	[PLANNED] biome content	Caldera hold contract, heat siege, failed expedition death site	Caldera Mantis, Heat Eel, Magma Skitter, Caldera Heat Kite, Eruption Sentry Bot
7	B7 — Precursor Ruin Belt	[PLANNED] biome content	Ledger vault finale, terraform viability verdict, ending choice	Vault Stalker, Silence Moth, Still Hunter Trace, Resonance Skimmer, Rust Garden, Corrupted Patrol Android

Underground Strata

Stratum	Name	Status	Freelancer / Story Role	Ecology / Threat Hooks
S1	Upper Lava Tubes	[PLANNED]	Smuggler crawl contracts, rival dead drops, expedition camp subsurface	Tube Lace, Tube Jackal, Cinder Tunnel Skitter, Rust Garden
S2	Mid Galleries	[PLANNED]	Escort shortcuts, Echo stabilization under fire	Glass Kelp, Rift Skimmer, Glass Hive Swarmer, Brood Tunnel Warden, Symbiosis Subject
S3	Deep Volatile Basins	[PLANNED]	High-pay retrieval jobs, brine convoy hazards	Brine Fan, Basin Mantis, Brine Hound, Lamprey Spire Colony, Brood Mother Chamber
S4	Geothermal Roots	[PLANNED]	Siege loot caches, caldera contract proof	Silicate Mirror Bloom, Heat Eel, Magma Phase Crawler, Tremor Larva
S5	Resonance Vaults	[PLANNED]	Kairos black-box vault, client list finale	Echo Lichen, Aether Seep Petal, Vault Stalker, Echo Symbiont Swarm, Corrupted Patrol Android

Life Sheet Coverage

Ecology visual source: Life Sheet set under [ArtReference/LifeSheets_RayTraced/](#) (read-only).

Sheet	Coverage	Package Use
RT_LifeSheet_B1_B2_Sulfur_Geyser.png	B1 + B2 organisms	Sulfur Hound, Vent Crabs, Plume Moths, convoy hazards
RT_LifeSheet_B3_B4_Ash_Caldera.png	B3 + B4 organisms	Dust Spouts, Basalt Jackals, Caldera Mantis, siege setpieces
RT_LifeSheet_B5_B6_Polar_Highlands.png	B5 + B6 organisms	Void Kelp, Magnet Wyrms, Tube Jackals, ridge contracts
RT_LifeSheet_B7_Ruins_Global.png	B7 + global organisms	Vault Stalker, Silence Moth, Still Hunter, Void Stitcher
RT_LifeSheet_Underground_S1_S2.png	S1-S2	Tube Lace, Glass Kelp, Brood Warden escort routes

Sheet	Coverage	Package Use
RT_LifeSheet_Underground_S3_S4_S5.png	S3-S5	Basin Mantis, Heat Eel, Echo Lichen ledger vaults
RT_LifeSheet_Threats_Androids_Humanoids.png	Androids + humanoids	Rival crew enforcers, Helix auditors, smuggler humanoids
RT_LifeSheet_Threats_Machines_Flyers.png	Machines + flyers	Scrap Mites, Ash Glass Wasps, siege drones, caravan turrets

4. Systems Inventory

System	Status	V4 Crimson Contract Use
Aether Credits economy	[SHIPPED]	Contract payouts, bid wars, escrow penalties, gear purchases; 5000 AC framed as 5% Mars final pay
Building Control Panels	[SHIPPED]	Freelancer HQ terminal: Overview Companions Production Craft Changes + contract board tab hooks
Echo chronicle / EchoGenerator	[SHIPPED]	Crew drama, missing-expedition Echo rescue, permanent fail consequence; Reid/Suri starter loyalty exempt from wary arc
Exposure / oxygen / pressure	[SHIPPED]	B5 cold-chain jobs, B4 heat sieges, B1 storm convoys, terraform viability stress tests
Sulfur Hound B1	[SHIPPED]	Paid hunt contract, escort ambush ecology, early spectacle
World Engine spine	[SHIPPED]	Contract boards, GameState job flags, Directors driving rival bids and Resonance Events
Combat	[SHIPPED]	Player weapons fluency, trio assault contracts, siege defense, rival crew clears
Weather	[PARTIAL]	Storm convoy windows, ash gale ridge holds, rad pulse escort timing
Quest framework	[PARTIAL]	Mainline progress triggers; contract boards for sides
Hovercraft / vehicle gating	[PARTIAL]	Caravan escorts, caldera approach, optional fast contract travel
Kairos / Memory Cores	[PLANNED]	Ledger repair spine, trust ladder, endings; name locked until prologue end
Full Io biomes	[PLANNED]	B1-B7 surface campaign, terraform survey lanes, ecology content
Underground	[PLANNED]	S1-S5 dead drops, ledger vaults, expedition blacksites
Communications	[PLANNED]	Client traffic, rival taunts, missing-expedition ping spam
Building modules	[PLANNED]	Escrow generator, relay mesh, siege defense, survey beacon modules

Freelancer Hooks Into Shipped/Planned Systems

- **Contract boards:** Fund survey milestones; jobs tagged with **viability data**, **expedition gap**, or **pure pay**.
- **Contract Lock Fields:** Barrier Fields mark active job perimeters — hold, escort, retrieve, or survive until timer ends.
- **World Engine:** Directors spawn rival ambushes, client overrides, and post-storm contract repricing.

- **Survey layer:** Suri Vale's terraform metrics run parallel to combat — discovery rewards feed viability report flags for endings.

5. AC Tier Curve And Reward Rules

AC Tier Curve

Tier	Campaign Range	Typical Reward	Use Cases
T1	Early B6/B1	150-450 AC	Starter board jobs, minor puzzles, first escorts
T2	B2/B3	500-950 AC	Mid contracts, ridge holds, weapon module rewards
T3	B5/B4	1100-2200 AC	Dangerous escorts, elite ecology hunts, ledger evidence
T4	B7 / endgame	2500-5200 AC	Vault jobs, client capstones, ending payouts, mastery prestige

Application Rules

- **Prologue / ML-01:** 5000 AC spend is **narrative retainer + charter**, not a generic grant; UI copy references **5% final Mars pay**.
- **Mainline:** Milestone payouts unlock cores, modules, and survey auth — not quest-giver dialogue trees.
- **Side quests:** Contract-board and crew-drama jobs scale T1-T4; often pay AC plus named gear or rep.
- **Puzzles:** Access Gate minority (~8). Loot/Cache/Weapon and Optional Mastery carry higher AC and kit.
- **Rival bids:** Underbid rivals for rep loss; overbid for margin squeeze — AC is also reputation currency.

Named Weapon And Module Families

Family	Examples	Reward Channels
Freelancer weapons	Survey Carbine, Crimson Pike, Escrow Spike	Iron Lark jobs, Contract Lock puzzles, player weapons fluency arc
Ledger tools	Ledger Lens, Redact Torch, Client Coil	Cartographer sides, vault puzzles, Burn ending
Shipment gear	Red Cutters, Mag-Claw, Fence Stamp	Red Shipment contracts, cache puzzles
Stitcher kit	Field Collar, Trauma Injector, Crew Band	Field Stitchers, Echo rescue jobs
Registry tools	Convoy Slate, Tariff Tag, Registry Pack	Convoy Registry, caravan escorts
Helix kit	Procurement Carbine, Audit Drone, Client Override Chip	Helix Procurement jobs, Crown ending
Veil gear	Veil Cloak, Mute Boots, Route Picks	Veil Route contracts, smuggler seals
Kairos modules	Escrow Capacitor, Resonance Baffle, Core-Sniffer Array	Mainline cores, B7 vaults, mastery

6. Mainline Progress-Triggered Arc

Mainline uses **progress triggers, not quest givers**. Contract NPCs and rival captains populate sides; the mainline advances through location, repair, core attachment, building online, survey thresholds, and Resonance.

Mainline Table

ID	Mainline Beat	Trigger	Biome / Site	Core / Repair	AC / Gear Reward	Est.	Status
ML-01	Prologue: Freelancer Arrival	B6 landing + charter boot + KairosNamed flag	B6 Survey HQ	Liaison shell ping	5000 AC retainer spend (5% final pay); Survey Sidearm ; Reid + Suri active	2.0h	[PLANNED] narrative
ML-02	Ledger Shell	Scan buried liaison casing under basalt ash (post-name)	B6 annex	Kairos shell found	300 AC; Ledger Lens Mk I	2.0h	[PLANNED]
ML-03	Escrow Auth Spindle	Enter first Contract Lock annex	B6 Lock Annex	Repair part 1	Escrow Spike Module	2.0h	[PLANNED]
ML-04	Convoy Capacitor Bank	Complete first B1 sulfur storm escort window	B1 Sulfur Plains	Repair part 2	450 AC; Storm Filter Module	2.5h	[PARTIAL] ecology via Sulfur Hound
ML-05	Client Coupler	Breach B2 seized rig inner lock after vent survey flag	B2 Geyser Fields	Repair part 3	Client Coil , unlock Kairos wake	2.5h	[PLANNED]
ML-06	Kairos Wake	Install all 3 repair parts in BCP-linked ledger cradle	Base Camp	Trust Angry	Escrow Capacitor Mk I	1.5h	[PLANNED]
ML-07	Core 1: Kill Receipt	Recover storm-buried escrow record; first missing-expedition name	B1	Memory Core 1	650 AC; Crimson Pike	3.0h	[PLANNED]
ML-08	Resonance 1: Overbid Hangover	Attach Core 1; Synergy Overcharge hits trio after bad bid	Base / B1	Trust Wary	Field Stabilizer Module	1.5h	[PLANNED]
ML-09	Core 2: Vent Escrow	Decode falsified vent lease after timed geyser vault	B2	Memory Core 2	900 AC; Geothermal Stabilizer	3.0h	[PLANNED]
ML-10	Resonance 2: Caravan Ledger	Install Geothermal Stabilizer through BCP	Base building	Building module unlock	Vent Seal Kit	1.5h	[PLANNED]
ML-11	Core 3: Jam Receipt	Break B3 signal jam contract sequence	B3 Ash Flats & Ridges	Memory Core 3	1200 AC; Relay Breaker SMG	3.0h	[PLANNED]

ID	Mainline Beat	Trigger	Biome / Site	Core / Repair	AC / Gear Reward	Est.	Status
ML-12	Resonance 3: Private Client	Signal blackout opens private Kairos trust scene	Base / B3 relay	Trust Advisor	Scout Relay Mesh	1.5h	[PLANNED]
ML-13	Core 4: Cold Courier Mirror	Recover illegal core from B5 polar cache job	B5 Polar Radiation Flats	Memory Core 4	1700 AC; Veil Cloak Module	3.0h	[PLANNED]
ML-14	Resonance 4: Double Escrow	Attach Core 4; rad inversion reveals rival ambush route	B5 / Base	Rad Suit Mk II	Core-Sniffer Array	1.5h	[PLANNED]
ML-15	Core 5: Caldera Hold Receipt	Find failed expedition death site under heat lock siege	B4 Lava Calderas	Memory Core 5	2100 AC; Procurement Carbine or Redact Torch Mk II	3.5h	[PLANNED]
ML-16	Resonance 5: The Job Killed Them	Building injury spike; BCP emergency crew triage	Base / B4	Trust Friend	Resonance Baffle	1.5h	[PLANNED]
ML-17	Core 6: Ledger Vault	Open B7 lock triad with repaired Kairos	B7 Precursor Ruin Belt	Memory Core 6	3000 AC; Kairos Ledger Key	4.0h	[PLANNED]
ML-18	Final Choice: Walk Away / Crown / Burn	Install Core 6; terraform viability report + doctrine terminal	B7 / Base	Ending triad	Ending-specific weapon/module; 5200 AC reserve grant	3.0h	[PLANNED]

Mainline subtotal: 41 hours.

Six Cores

Core	Name	Biome	Ledger Truth	Resonance Event	Unlock	Freelancer Meaning
C1	Kill Receipt	B1	First deniable kill order; expedition name redacted	Synergy Overcharge: trio buff then payroll glitch	Probe Uplink Tower	Missing crews were billed before buried
C2	Vent Escrow	B2	Vent leases were prepaid kill zones; bad for terraform	Stability Bubble over one rival HQ	Geothermal Stabilizer	Infrastructure fraud skews viability math
C3	Jam Receipt	B3	Signal jam billed as "security"; hid distress calls	12-minute Comms Blackout	Scout Relay Mesh	Whoever owns comms owns the disappearance narrative
C4	Courier Mirror	B5	Illegal cores moved as "medical courier" jobs	Cold Lens rad inversion	Rad Suit Mk II	Smugglers and clients share expedition cover stories
C5	Caldera Hold Receipt	B4	Expedition crew died holding a contract line	Magma Mirror + base injury spike	Heat Lock Override	Terraform viability fails if truth stays buried
C6	Ledger Vault	B7	Kairos can cash out, crown, or burn all clients	Resonance Supercell Lite	Vault doctrine terminal	You choose what your report <i>and</i> your company become

Trust Dialogue Ladder

Trust Stage	Trigger	Kairos Voice
Angry	Wake after repair parts	"You are not directors anymore. You are survey labor with rifles."
Wary	Core 1	"Receipt logged. Which missing name do you invoice first?"
Adversarial Advisor	Core 2	"That Contract Lock is not geology. It is a clause that deletes witnesses."
Cynical Partner	Core 3	"Rival bid accepted. Your viability curve still assumes honest clients."
Quiet Confessor	Core 4	"The courier was illegal. The client was Helix. Mars taught you nothing?"
Friend	Core 5	"They died holding the line because retreat wasn't in the contract."
Final Witness	Core 6	"Walk away, crown the company, or burn the ledger. Suri will ask which truth you publish."

Endings

Ending	Choice	Outcome	Reward
Walk Away	Take restored cores, crew, viability data, and cash; abandon Io client board	Freelancers survive off-moon; Io stays wild; honest "conditional/no-go" terraform report	Ledger Satchel Prime , crew loyalty cap, high AC reserve
Crown the Company	Become Io's sanctioned contractor cartel with Kairos as liaison	Stable pay, strong gear, moral gray dominance; viability report classified	Crimson Crown Module , Procurement Carbine Prime, Contract Lock control
Burn the Ledger	Broadcast all client kill receipts, escrow routes, and expedition gaps	Client networks collapse locally; public terraform fraud + disappearance proof	Redact Torch Prime , public proof codex, Veil Route amnesty fork

7. Side Quests — 40

Side quests blend contract-board work, survey discovery, rival crews, and specialist drama.

ID	Title	Faction / Source	Biome	Type	Objective	AC Tier / Reward	Gear / Module	Est.
SQ-01	First Blood Bid	Iron Lark board	B6	Contract	Break up rival salvage fight; collect fee	T1 250 AC	Crimson Plate Liner	1.2h
SQ-02	Spike The Job Zone	Iron Lark marshal	B3	Territory	Hold Contract Lock on contested ash route	T1 350 AC	Escrow Spike	1.3h
SQ-03	Storm Convoy	Iron Lark board	B1	Escort	Move survey cargo through sulfur storm window	T2 600 AC	Survey Carbine	1.4h

ID	Title	Faction / Source	Biome	Type	Objective	AC Tier / Reward	Gear / Module	Est.
SQ-04	Silent Wire	Iron Lark scout	B3	Stealth / Combat	Clear android relay without losing bonus pay	T2 700 AC	Mute Sling Module	1.3h
SQ-05	Lock Brief	Iron Lark analyst	B3	Recon	Map 3 Contract Locks and identify client keys	T2 650 AC	Lock matrix update	1.1h
SQ-06	Lark Legend	Iron Lark captain	B4	Escort / Siege	Protect summit courier through Caldera Mantis hold	T3 1700 AC	Crimson Pike Mk II	1.8h
SQ-07	Receipt Primer	Signal Cartographers board	B1	Evidence	Collect ledger scraps from failed isotope camp	T1 300 AC	Ledger Lens	1.1h
SQ-08	Fake Lease	Cartographer whistleblower	B2	Investigation	Prove Helix vent lease contradicts Suri's survey data	T2 750 AC	Redact Torch	1.3h
SQ-09	Polar Whistle	Cartographers board	B5	Evidence	Choose smuggler records or Helix logs first	T3 1400 AC	Sample Case Mk II	1.5h
SQ-10	Publish Fork	Cartographer council	B6	Choice	Leak early for chaos or hold for vault leverage	T2 900 AC	Cartographer rep fork	1.0h
SQ-11	Shelf Frequency	Cartographer specialist	B7	Puzzle / Lore	Tune Echo Shelves to decode client backups	T4 2600 AC	Client Coil	1.4h
SQ-12	Ledger Finale	Cartographers board	B7	Evidence Capstone	Recover secondary black-box shard	T4 3200 AC	Redact Torch Prime	1.5h
SQ-13	Contested Haul	Red Shipment board	B1	Salvage	Beat rivals to storm-exposed wreck	T1 400 AC	Red Cutters	1.2h
SQ-14	Mag Debt	Shipment foreman	B2	Salvage	Retrieve Mag-Claw from Helix-sealed vent pit	T2 700 AC	Mag-Claw	1.2h
SQ-15	Fence Night	Shipment broker	B3	Stealth / Trade	Move fence stamp through Contract Lock checkpoint	T2 850 AC	Fence Stamp	1.1h
SQ-16	Crust Drop	Shipment board	S1-S3	Depth Push	Recover dead drop under unsafe crust	T3 1500 AC	Crust Anchor Module	1.5h
SQ-17	Price War	Shipment / Registry dispute	B6	Debate	Break or endorse Registry tariffs	T2 800 AC	Vendor fee modifier	0.9h
SQ-18	Shipment Legend	Shipment syndics	B4	Salvage Capstone	Loot contract wreck during heat lull	T3 1900 AC	Red Cutter Mk II	1.7h
SQ-19	After Overbid	Field Stitches board	B6	Medical / Echo	Treat Rebooted trio member after bad bid job	T1 450 AC	Field Collar	1.2h

ID	Title	Faction / Source	Biome	Type	Objective	AC Tier / Reward	Gear / Module	Est.
SQ-20	Reid's Line	Field Stitchers / Reid Kael	B3	Companion	Hold ridge under Helix audit pressure — Reid already trusts you ; beat is tactical cost, not loyalty test	T2 850 AC	Reid bond perk	1.3h
SQ-21	Draven Stabilized	Field Stitchers / Draven-4	B1	Companion	Stabilize hostile imprint after weaponized Echo scare	T2 900 AC	Trauma Injector	1.4h
SQ-22	Solara Heat	Field Stitchers / Solara	B4	Companion	Keep thermal lab survivor off Helix custody lists	T3 1650 AC	Solara bond perk	1.3h
SQ-23	Suri's Draft	Field Stitchers / Dr. Suri Vale	B2	Companion / Evidence	Use seismic receipt to fix Suri's viability draft — she trusts your field data ; beat is scientific integrity vs client pressure	T2 950 AC	Crew Band	1.3h
SQ-24	Stitcher Soften	Field Stitchers board	B6	Stabilization	Cleanse weaponize Saturation from one building loop	T3 1300 AC	Stitcher Soften Module	1.2h
SQ-25	Registry Open	Convoy Registry board	B6	Founding	Stand up neutral contract desk	T1 200 AC	Registry Pack	0.8h
SQ-26	Tariff Storm	Registry dispatcher	B1	Escort	Deliver contracts through shifting storm claims	T2 650 AC	Convoy Slate	1.3h
SQ-27	Vent Broker	Registry board	B2	Escort / Trade	Run neutral convoy past vent lease checkpoints	T2 750 AC	Tariff Tag	1.2h
SQ-28	Signal Fee	Registry adjudicator	B3	Choice	Pay, break, or redirect jam monopoly	T2 950 AC	Tariff Cut Module	1.3h
SQ-29	Polar Broker	Registry board	B5	Delivery	Maintain cold-chain custody of evidence	T3 1550 AC	Registry vendor discount	1.2h
SQ-30	Registry Legend	Registry summit clerk	B7	Escort Capstone	Carry final ledger logistics through silent corridors	T4 2800 AC	Convoy Slate Prime	1.6h
SQ-31	Lease Drop	Helix Procurement Office	B2	Client Entry	Accept visitor status without ceding freelancer sovereignty	T1 350 AC	Client Override Chip	0.8h
SQ-32	Seizure	Helix contract board	B1	Combat / Seizure	Seize Shipment crate under corporate paperwork	T2 800 AC	Audit Drone	1.2h
SQ-33	Compliance	Helix auditor	B5	Recon	Audit Veil routes without tipping Iron Lark	T3 1600 AC	Procurement Armor	1.4h
SQ-34	Override Trial	Helix client rep	B7	Puzzle / Access	Open corporate vault seal with client override	T4 3000 AC	Override Module	1.5h

ID	Title	Faction / Source	Biome	Type	Objective	AC Tier / Reward	Gear / Module	Est.
SQ-35	Helix Ultimatum	Helix Procurement Office	B6	Choice Capstone	Ally, burn, or crown with Helix at the table	T4 4200 AC	Procurement Carbine	1.1h
SQ-36	Veil Meet	Veil Route Brokers	B5	Client Entry	Buy first Route Pick and learn smuggler map	T1 300 AC	Mute Boots	0.8h
SQ-37	Sleeve Run	Veil board	B5	Stealth	Move false core past Iron Lark scanners	T3 1450 AC	Veil Cloak	1.4h
SQ-38	Stitcher Tip	Veil survivor	B3	Encounter / Lore	Verify: "Do not trust the seams."	T3 1300 AC	Veil Needle Armor Mod	1.3h
SQ-39	Lock Market	Veil board	B3	Puzzle / Trade	Buy, sell, or burn Contract Lock bypass market	T3 1750 AC	Route Pick Skill	1.5h
SQ-40	Veil Legend	Veil Route Brokers	B7	Silent Escort	Move protected asset past Still Hunter pressure	T4 3500 AC	Route Picks Prime	1.8h

Side quest subtotal: 51 hours.

8. Puzzles — 40 Purpose-Typed

Purpose distribution:

- **Access Gate:** 8
- **Loot / Cache / Weapon:** 8
- **Environmental Survival:** 7
- **Combat / Encounter:** 6
- **Story / Reveal:** 6
- **Optional Mastery:** 5

ID	Title	Purpose	Biome / Site	Solve Grammar	AC Tier / Reward	Gear / Module	Est.
PQ-01	Annex Contract Lock	Access Gate	B6 annex	Hack, Lark key, or Veil pick	T1 150 AC	Opens Escrow Auth Spindle route	1.0h
PQ-02	Capacitor Storm Lock	Access Gate	B1 isotope camp	Open during sulfur storm lull	T1 250 AC	Storm Filter Module	1.1h
PQ-03	Coupler Choice Gate	Access Gate	B2 seized rig	Helix chip or Veil pick	T2 500 AC	Client Coupler	1.2h
PQ-04	Veil Seal A	Access Gate	B5 polar route	Route Pick timing	T2 650 AC	Opens Veil route	1.0h
PQ-05	Contract Heat Lock	Access Gate	B4 death site	Heat Override and cooled crust path	T3 1200 AC	Heat Lock Override	1.3h

ID	Title	Purpose	Biome / Site	Solve Grammar	AC Tier / Reward	Gear / Module	Est.
PQ-06	Ledger Locks A	Access Gate	B7 outer vault	Three surface locks	T4 2500 AC	Vault access flag	1.5h
PQ-07	Triple Key Lock	Access Gate	Act III shared route	Lark + Cartographer + Veil tools	T3 1800 AC	Ledger Key Fragment	1.5h
PQ-08	Burn Seal	Access Gate	Final terminal	Seven-faction seal alignment	T4 3200 AC	Burn ending route	1.5h
PQ-09	Lark Armory	Loot/Cache/Weapon	B6 HQ	Trusted board rank + safe combination	T1 300 AC	Survey Carbine	0.8h
PQ-10	Shipment Mag-Lock	Loot/Cache/Weapon	B1 yard	Mag-Claw lift and fence code	T1 350 AC	Red Cutters	0.9h
PQ-11	Cartographer Cleanroom	Loot/Cache/Weapon	B5 lab	Contamination route puzzle	T2 800 AC	Redact Torch Mk II	1.0h
PQ-12	Helix Black Seal	Loot/Cache/Weapon	B2 lander	Client chip sequence	T2 950 AC	Procurement Carbine Mod	1.1h
PQ-13	Veil False Wall	Loot/Cache/Weapon	B5 smuggler cut	Mute Boots + Route Pick	T2 900 AC	Veil Cloak Liner	1.0h
PQ-14	Crust Lottery Drop	Loot/Cache/Weapon	S3 volatile basin	Lattice path memorization	T3 1500 AC	Crust Anchor Module	1.2h
PQ-15	Android Dig Lease	Loot/Cache/Weapon	B7 dig	Cipher proves lease fraud, then unlocks frame	T4 2800 AC	Audit Drone Upgrade	1.3h
PQ-16	Crown Cage	Loot/Cache/Weapon	Final weapon vault	Arm or disarm ledger safely	T4 3600 AC	Crimson Crown Rifle	1.4h
PQ-17	Void Kelp Wire	Environmental Survival	B5 kelp grove	Scan quietly through rad pulse	T2 750 AC	Rad-shield gel recipe	1.1h
PQ-18	Flooded Tube Brief	Environmental Survival	S2 flooded junction	Wade route and O2 timing	T2 600 AC	O2 Valve Module	1.0h
PQ-19	Cover Relay Bribe	Environmental Survival	B5/B4 relay	Cross pulse/heat cover lanes; bribe optional	T3 1400 AC	Relay Baffle	1.2h
PQ-20	Spout Checkpoint	Environmental Survival	B3 ash route	Predict Dust Spout paths	T2 700 AC	Ash ceramic cache	1.0h
PQ-21	Pulse Toll	Environmental Survival	B2 geyser bridge	Pay tariff or master vent timing	T2 650 AC	Vent shortcut unlock	1.0h
PQ-22	Gas Dome Blacksite	Environmental Survival	S4/S5 blacksite	Vent pressure and Redact Read	T3 1700 AC	Gas Dome Filter	1.3h
PQ-23	Silent Summit Path	Environmental Survival	B7 silent zone	Avoid Silence Moths and Still Hunter trace	T4 2600 AC	Summit escort shortcut	1.1h
PQ-24	Receipt Cage	Combat/Encounter	B1 Core 1 vault	Pattern solve while drones fire	T2 800 AC	Crimson Pike	1.2h
PQ-25	Reboot Chamber	Combat/Encounter	Base emergency room	Stabilize lace puzzle under sync aftershock	T2 700 AC	Trauma Injector Module	1.1h

ID	Title	Purpose	Biome / Site	Solve Grammar	AC Tier / Reward	Gear / Module	Est.
PQ-26	Rockfall Ambush	Combat/Encounter	S1/S2 tunnel	Drop rocks on rival pursuers or block escape	T2 850 AC	Tunnel route unlock	1.1h
PQ-27	Multi-Breach Lock	Combat/Encounter	B3 ridge maze	Blast, quiet route, or bribe under ambush	T3 1300 AC	Escrow Spike Mk II	1.2h
PQ-28	Petal Blackmail	Combat/Encounter	B7 vault	Align petal under Hunter pressure	T4 3000 AC	Vault Glass Mod	1.5h
PQ-29	Void Stitcher Proof	Combat/Encounter	Global seam POI	Survive reveal, force retreat, collect seam needle	T3 1800 AC	Veil Needle Armor Mod	1.3h
PQ-30	Vent Escrow Vault	Story/Reveal	B2 vent vault	Compare Suri's scanner truth to false papers	T2 900 AC	Core 2 evidence	1.2h
PQ-31	Jam Receipt Gate	Story/Reveal	B3 beacons	Break jam monopoly sequence	T2 950 AC	Core 3 evidence	1.2h
PQ-32	Frequency Blackmail	Story/Reveal	B7 Echo Shelf	Wrong pitch raises Saturation threat	T3 1500 AC	Helix blackmail file	1.2h
PQ-33	Dual Blacksite	Story/Reveal	S5 vault approach	Two-dome synchronization	T3 1700 AC	Rare proof cache	1.2h
PQ-34	Ledger Locks B	Story/Reveal	B7 inner vault	Petals + faction keys reveal Kairos truth	T4 3000 AC	Core 6 route	1.5h
PQ-35	Doctrine Seal	Story/Reveal	Final chamber	Walk Away, Crown, or Burn doctrine lock	T4 4200 AC	Ending doctrine	1.6h
PQ-36	Lock Cascade	Optional Mastery	B3 contested field	Link 3 Contract Locks to reroute job ownership	T3 1900 AC	Contract map overlay	1.4h
PQ-37	Bid Auction	Optional Mastery	B6 generator	Bid AC, siphon Strain, or steal rival key	T3 2200 AC	Master Lock Key	1.4h
PQ-38	Registry Vault	Optional Mastery	B6 market	Convoy Slate timing across factions	T2 1000 AC	Registry vendor upgrade	1.0h
PQ-39	Veil Seal B	Optional Mastery	B5 Core 4 vault	Dual Seal + Ledger Lens	T3 2100 AC	Route Picks Prime Part	1.3h
PQ-40	Caldera Mantis Trophy Lock	Optional Mastery	B4 rim cache	Lure mantis into heat shadow pressure trap	T4 3100 AC	Mantis Shell Armor Module	1.5h

Puzzle subtotal: 48 hours.

9. Factions V4

FB1 — Iron Lark Company

Role: Security mercs, route muscle, "hold the line until the timer pays."

Formation trigger: First public injury during contested B6 salvage bid.

Board fantasy: Hold contracts, escort muscle, ridge defense, rival clears.

Signature gear: Crimson Plate, Survey Carbine, Escrow Spike, Crimson Pike.

Conflict lines: Hates Veil bypasses, distrusts Shipment theft, resents Helix client overrides.

FB2 — Signal Cartographers

Role: Intel / science crew — decode jam patterns, map locks, sell truth.

Formation trigger: Core 1 proves kill receipts were routed through jam relays.

Board fantasy: Evidence recovery, client decode, expedition gap hunts.

Signature gear: Ledger Lens, Redact Torch, Client Coil, Sample Case.

Conflict lines: Burn ending ally; Crown ending opponent unless careerists win.

FB3 — Red Shipment Guild

Role: Salvage syndics, rough labor, practical thieves with good trucks.

Formation trigger: First contested haul after B1 storm salvage opens.

Board fantasy: Hauls, fences, dead drops, convoy loot, lock subversion.

Signature gear: Red Cutters, Mag-Claw, Fence Stamp, Crust Anchor.

Conflict lines: Says Iron Lark protects invoices, not people.

FB4 — Field Stitchers

Role: Medical, Echo triage, anti-weaponize conscience with field pragmatism.

Formation trigger: First Synergy Overcharge / Reboot after a bad bid job.

Board fantasy: Stabilization, rescue contracts, anti-Saturation work, crew trauma.

Signature gear: Field Collar, Trauma Injector, Crew Band, Stitcher Soften Module.

Conflict lines: Opposes Helix and Crown ending if Echo weaponization spikes.

FB5 — Convoy Registry

Role: Logistics brokers, tariff clerks, contract counters — neutral on paper.

Formation trigger: AC market surplus and disputed board payment after B2/B3.

Board fantasy: Convoys, price disputes, escrow paperwork, settlement enforcement.

Signature gear: Registry Pack, Convoy Slate, Tariff Tag, Crimson Crown Module.

Conflict lines: Crown ending backbone; accused of selling survival by the kilometer.

FX1 — Helix Procurement Office

Role: External corporate client — pays well, owns your mistakes.

Arrival trigger: Kairos repair wake plus B2 lease evidence.

Board fantasy: Compliance contracts, seizures, audits, client override events.

Signature gear: Procurement Armor, Procurement Carbine, Audit Drone, Client Override Chip.

Conflict lines: Wants Kairos as permanent liaison; offers to erase Mars stranding record.

FX2 — Veil Route Brokers

Role: External smuggler rivals — illegal routes, better margins, worse friends.

Arrival trigger: Core 4 courier thread and polar route rumors.

Board fantasy: Route picks, false walls, dead drops, silent escorts.

Signature gear: Veil Cloak, Mute Boots, Route Picks, Veil Needle Armor Mod.

Conflict lines: Treats every Contract Lock as a price tag on honesty.

10. Friction And Contract Lock Matrix

Friction Set

ID	Friction	Effect	Primary Counterplay
F1	Contract Lock Field	Blocks routes, caches, HQ wings, and job zones until contract terms met	Faction key, hack, bribe, storm window, Veil pick
F2	Escrow Seal	Hides contraband paths, bonus caches, and dead drops	Route Pick, Mute Boots, Ledger Lens
F3	Vault Lock Triad	Requires surface locks plus B7 petal alignment	Core progress, faction keys, Kairos trust
F4	Storm Convoy Window	Escort rights and pay multipliers shift during weather peaks	Timed travel, board contract, Lark or Shipment rep
F5	Echo Sync Gamble	Echo rescue can fail permanently; weaponize route increases risk	Field Stitcher tools, lower Saturation, careful trio choices
F6	Rad / Heat Permit Gate	B5/B4 pressure zones require kit, permit, or route mastery	Rad Suit Mk II, Heat Lock Override, Registry permits
F7	Siege Timer	Hold/defend contracts fail if timer expires under pressure	Defense modules, trio positioning, Iron Lark rep
F8	Rival Crew Ambush	Competing freelancers bid against or attack active jobs	Combat, stealth, bribe, Cartographer intel
F9	Client Override	Helix can hijack board posts, seize escrow, or rewrite job terms	Burn evidence, Crown auth, Registry counter-filing
F10	Still Hunter / Void Stitcher Pressure	Apex pressure forces route, quiet, or retreat — "moon collects debts"	Scout warning, Reid Tactician block, silence discipline

Contract Lock Gate Matrix

Lock Group	Location	Owner Bias	Blocks	Unlock Routes	Freelancer Consequence
CL-01	B6 Annex Field	Iron Lark / Helix	Escrow Auth Spindle	Hack, Lark rank, Helix chip, Veil pick	First lesson: access is a contract clause
CL-02	B1 Storm Convoy Ring	Iron Lark / Shipment	Isotope camp escort	Storm timing, board contract, bribe	Funds early survey; exposes disappearance pings

Lock Group	Location	Owner Bias	Blocks	Unlock Routes	Freelancer Consequence
CL-03	B2 Lease Fence	Helix / Cartographers	Seized rig inner	Lease proof, Client chip, vent timing	Skews terraform viability data
CL-04	B3 Jam Gate	Registry / Helix	Relay mesh	Pay jam fee, break signal, Cartographer proof	Sets comms monopoly reputation
CL-05	B3 Lock Cascade	Iron Lark / Veil	Four contested POIs	Link fields, steal key, broker bid	Converts side territory into company leverage
CL-06	B5 Polar Seal Grid	Veil / Helix	Illegal core cache	Route Pick, Compliance audit, rad permit	Determines Core 4 public story
CL-07	B4 Heat Permit Lock	Registry / Iron Lark	Expedition death site	Heat Override, escort writ, mastery route	Decides who testifies at vault finale
CL-08	B7 Ledger Vault Field	All factions	Core 6 and endings	Three surface locks, petal alignment, faction keys	Final client table + viability verdict

Company Payday Summit

Side/faction content visible around Core 6 — not the mainline giver. Mainline triggers vault and doctrine terminal; summit decides which clients attend, what receipts enter the record, and whether the final choice has crew legitimacy.

Summit Lever	Source	Effect
Public receipts	Signal Cartographers	Strengthens Burn the Ledger
Hold pledge	Iron Lark Company	Strengthens Crown or Walk Away with muscle
Worker vote	Red Shipment Guild	Lowers AC tariffs if respected
Echo triage charter	Field Stitchers	Weakens Crown weaponization, protects Echo rescue
Escrow schedule	Convoy Registry	Makes Crown enforceable
Corporate indemnity	Helix Procurement	Makes Crown easier, Burn harder
Route immunity	Veil Route Brokers	Opens Walk Away smuggler exfil or Burn blackmail

11. Hour Budget

Exploration/free roam is excluded from the designed total.

Bucket	Hours
Mainline progress-triggered arc (incl. prologue ML-01)	41
Side quests, 40 total	51
Puzzles, 40 total	48
Faction reputation, contract boards, rival bids	16

Bucket	Hours
Systemic repeatables, storm convoys, escort reruns, elite pressure	16
Designed total	172
Exploration / free roam bonus	Not counted (~25-40h ambience, hunting, vistas)

Repeatable Content Budget

Repeatable	Est.	Notes
Contract Lock re-contests after sulfur storms / ash gales	5h	Job repricing, board updates, AC bounties
Reputation board contracts	4h	Faction-specific repeatable variants
Storm convoy windows	3h	B1/B3/B5 escort pressure gates
Evidence runs / blacksite reroutes	2h	Cartographer, Helix, Veil variants
Elite pressure events	2h	Void Stitcher, Still Hunter trace, Magnet Wyrms, Caldera Mantis

12. Sample Dialogue And Contract Board Snippets

Kairos

"The first lie was archive. The second was safety. The third was that survey labor gets paid enough to forgive the receipt."

"A Contract Lock is not a wall. It is a timer wearing armor."

"Your Mars director chair was revoked by invoice. Io will revoke you by sulfur."

Reid "Iron" Kael

"You say jump, I ask which ridge. Mars didn't break us. Don't let Io think it can."

"I don't care if the moon is viable. I care if the thing in the ash ridge flanks left."

Dr. Suri Vale

"You promoted me when the lab said I was too junior. I didn't follow you to Io to doubt you now."

"I won't sign 'terraform feasible' until we explain where the expeditions went. Missing data is not neutral."

Iron Lark Company

"We do not hold the line because we love Io. We hold it because the invoice says thirty more minutes."

Helix Procurement Office

"Dark Matter did not discover Kairos. You opened a sealed liability. Our offer is not ownership. It is retention with benefits — and a clean Mars file."

Contract Board Snippets

Post	Snippet	Mechanical Hook
Survey: Baseline Grid	"Freelancer charter clause 7: map B6 thermal variance. Pay on upload."	Terraform viability flag
Hold: Ridge Seven	"Hold until timer. Pay triple if Caldera Mantis breaches early."	Siege timer + ecology setpiece
Missing: Expedition 14	"Recover survey slate from sulfur graveyard. No bodies expected."	Disappearance mystery
Bid War: Vent Rig	"Helix lowballed. Beat by 200 AC or lose rep."	AC margin vs reputation fork
Override: Client Seizure	"Helix asserts escrow seizure. Contest or comply."	Client Override friction

Ending Closing Lines

Walk Away:

Kairos: "The ledger closes. Take your report, your crew, and your name. Io keeps billing someone else."

Crown the Company:

Kairos: "You did not terraform Io. You franchised survival. Suri will hate the redactions."

Burn the Ledger:

Kairos: "Every client name is ash now. That is not justice. It is a receipt they cannot file — and a report they cannot suppress."

13. Package Summary

V4 Crimson Contract centers a **freelance terraform surveyor** stranded by Mars corporate betrayal, arriving on Io with **5000 AC (5% final pay)**, **old friends Reid Kael and Dr. Suri Vale** (complete trust from day one — no starter loyalty arc), and a charter to assess **terraform viability** and **missing expeditions**. Off-beat contract-board spectacle funds the survey while **Kairos** — named only at **prologue end** — reveals a black-box mercenary ledger tying clients to disappeared crews. Mainline

progression remains trigger-driven through repair parts, Memory Cores, building unlocks, Resonance Events, and final doctrine choice.

Designed total: 172 hours, exploration excluded.

Core fantasy: Discover why Io eats expeditions. Survive the contracts that pay for the truth. Choose what your report — and your company — become when Kairos opens the vault.